

IPO boom backs Beijing's tech ambitions

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Blockbuster listings from Unitree and CXMT reinforce how Beijing's push to finance homegrown alternatives to Western technology is finding strong rece|||||||

China Weekly

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Blockbuster IPOs fund Beijing's homegrown technology drive

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Notice

China Weekly is publishing every other week in August and will resume its normal weekly schedule in September.

Economic Policy

Unitree's blockbuster IPO is the latest demonstration of China's domestic capital markets stepping up to fund strategic tech firms. The listing follows a similar milestone for memory chipmaker CXMT—its recent IPO reinforced that Beijing's push to develop homegrown alternatives to Western technology is finding receptive investors domestically. Unitree, the first general-purpose humanoid robotics company to list on mainland China's stock market, closed its debut session on 19 August at a staggering 857 times projected 2026 earnings.

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Capital is shifting toward hard tech. Unitree's listing reinforces a broader rotation from China's traditional internet leaders toward robotics, AI, and advanced manufacturing. We expect this pipeline to grow as Beijing continues to support strategic technologies. As AgiBot, Galbot and X Square Robot prepare to list, a growing supply of comparable names will offer investors alternatives and should ease demand for Unitree's shares.

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China tech valuation is becoming more bifurcated. Shein's large discount in valuation (expected IPO in Hong Kong at the end of August) reflects external regulatory pressures. Investors are increasingly discounting consumer-internet platforms such as Alibaba and PDD while rewarding names in so-called hard tech. We expect this divergence to persist, making sector selection increasingly important for China equity investors.

Graphic of the Week

Politics

Beijing is using Jiang Zemin's centenary to reinforce Xi's authority. On 17 August, the Chinese Communist Party held a commemorative ceremony to mark the 100th anniversary of former General Secretary Jiang Zemin's birth, with Xi Jinping delivering the keynote address. Xi's speech used Jiang's legacy to reinforce his own current political priorities, including absolute party leadership, ideological discipline, and the significance of having one "core" leader.

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Xi's speech drew on Jiang's record as a vehicle for current political messaging. The content tracked Xi's own priorities: loyalty to the party center, anti-corruption, new quality productivity, and national rejuvenation. That pattern suggests Beijing will continue to invoke the party's historical record to reinforce Xi's authority in the run-up to the 21st Party Congress in 2027, presenting continuity of leadership as continuity of the party's mission.

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The attendance list sent an equally deliberate signal. Every major retired leader appeared, including former Premier Wen Jiabao, who for years has been largely absent from public life. That rare show of cross-generational unity suggests the leadership is projecting internal cohesion. Heading into 2027, the appearance of a unified party establishment will matter as a counter to any perception of disagreement or factions at the top.

Foreign Policy

Beijing uses US unreliability to pull Seoul closer. Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi visited South Korea on 19–20 August and met with President Lee Jae-myung and other senior officials. The visit comes shortly after President Donald Trump on 16 August ordered the Pentagon to scale back joint military exercises with South Korea, saying the exercises would send a "hostile" signal to North Korea.

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Trump's comments were not the catalyst for Wang's long-planned visit, but gave additional impetus to the diplomatic outreach that China and South Korea have been pursuing since last year. The trip is Wang's first standalone visit to Seoul since September 2021 and follows high-level exchanges between Xi and Lee in November and January. Wang's trip will prepare the ground for a meeting between Xi and Lee on the sidelines of APEC in Shenzhen in November.

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Beijing used the visit to emphasize the economic benefits of strong China-South Korea ties and urged Seoul to act independently of Washington. China's readouts of Wang's meetings described its domestic market as offering South Korea an "enormous opportunity" and urged Seoul to exercise "genuine strategic autonomy."

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China likely also sought to present itself as an important actor for achieving a breakthrough on North Korea. Beijing seeks to accrue leverage with both Seoul and Washington as both Presidents Lee and Trump have expressed their interest in restarting dialogue with North Korean leader Kim Jong-un. China's readout said that Beijing is committed to playing a "constructive role" on the Korean peninsula.

US-China

The US will pursue targeted decoupling while preserving summit prospects. On 13 August, the Trump administration announced new Section 232 tariffs on drones and drone components, which would disproportionately affect Chinese-made drones.

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While China is expected to retaliate, the 232 action will complicate the relationship without disrupting the upcoming Xi visit to Washington. Beijing could respond with reciprocal tariffs on selected US products or expand export controls applying to US drone manufacturers that stand to benefit from the 232 measures. China could also wait for additional US actions before responding with a consolidated retaliatory package, as it did in early August regarding FCC and Uyghur protection actions. Beijing will likely frame countermeasures as negotiable, but their removal would depend on US concessions—particularly the rollback of earlier measures—which remains unlikely.

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Washington will manage the timing of tougher measures with upcoming diplomacy in mind. The Federal Communications Commission (FCC) looks set to introduce further restrictions on sensitive Chinese technology imports, including optical transceivers, which are key inputs for AI data centers. That announcement is, however, likely delayed until later in the year to avoid disrupting Xi's September visit.

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China is also signaling summit support through its limited H200 approval. The announcement on 19 August mirrors Beijing's approval of the TikTok transaction earlier this year, ahead of Trump's visit to China. The approval is intended to demonstrate good faith ahead of the summit, but it is unlikely to result in large-scale H200 imports because Beijing remains wary of dependence on US chips that it believes domestic firms could soon match. Chinese officials have indicated greater interest in access to higher-end chips, such as Nvidia's Blackwell, though US approval remains highly unlikely.

Standing Calls in 2026

Notes underpinning calls:

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Beneath the US-China truce, AI and commercial pressures are mounting , 5 August 2026

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Latest dismissals deepen military turmoil and lower Taiwan risk , 26 January 2026

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Trade confrontation will escalate despite managed pause , 2 July 2026

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Beijing will maintain calibrated pressure campaign against Tokyo , 20 July 2026

Upcoming Events

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12-13 September: BRICS Summit

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24 September: Xi will likely visit the US

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22-29 September: UN General Assembly high-level meetings

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27 September: Six-month deadline for China's trade investigations

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October: 5th Plenum of the 20th CCP Central Committee

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1-7 October: China's National Day/Golden Week

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10 October: Taiwan's National Day

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21-23 October: Bund Summit in Shanghai (estimated dates)

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10 November: End of one-year suspension of US-China tariffs, Bureau of Industry and Security 50% ruling, Chinese export controls, port fees

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18-19 November: APEC summit in Shenzhen

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28 November: Taiwan local elections

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14-15 December: G20 leaders' summit in Miami

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